

APPLYING TO GRADUATE SCHOOL

Deciding to attend graduate school is a big decision. In the list of reasons to attend, you might be considering that it may improve your professional prospects, satisfy a degree requirement for your career, or deepen your knowledge in a particular field. Thoughtfully consider your reasons for attending, just as you would when deciding on an undergraduate degree or program (The Condition of Education Annual Report , 2020).

Below are some reasons to consider why you should attend graduate school:

- The career you've chosen requires it for you to be successful in that field.
- You want to obtain professional training in a specific area.
- You love learning and want to advance your knowledge and skills in a particular field.

As you are researching potential career and graduate choices, it is wise to speak to professors and alumni in your interest field. Review graduate school websites and talk to admissions representatives to determine if and when the optimal time to attend.

Once you decide that graduate school is appropriate, the next step is to develop a plan of action:

- By junior year at YU, you should start to investigate schools in your area of interest.
- [Peterson's Guide to Graduate Programs](#) and [Best Graduate Schools U.S. News and World Report Rankings](#) are useful resources.
- Determine the entrance requirements for the graduate school program of your choice.
- Review the cost, size, geographic location, entrance requirements, and quality of the programs.
- Visit the school's website and speak to an admissions representative, ensuring you meet the necessary entrance requirements.
- You may want to take note of members of the faculty and review their areas of research. Determine whether they are working on topics that are of interest to you. Speak to alumni who attended the school to gain their feedback on the program.
- Begin to narrow your choices. [Create an Excel spreadsheet](#) to log the schools and compare preferences, i.e., cost, size, location, entrance requirements, etc.
- Depending on the type of program, you might have anywhere from five to twenty schools on your list.
- Talk to professors about the writing of recommendation letters.
- Depending on the program, register for the entrance exam and study. You may want to find a test preparation program.

TYPICAL DEGREES

The more popular advanced degrees available are:

- | | |
|--|--|
| • Ph.D. (Doctor of Philosophy) | • M.B.A. (Master of Business Administration) |
| • M.D. (Doctor of Medicine), | • MN (Master of Nursing) |
| • Ed.D. (Doctor of Education) J.D. (Juris Doctorate) | • M.S.W. (Master of Social Work) |
| • M.S. (Master of Science) | • M.Ed. (Master of Education) |
| • M.A. (Master of Arts) | |

Note: This is not a comprehensive list of degrees, so make sure you are researching the program and degree that best fits you.



EXAMS

Many programs require you to take specialized entrance exams. These tests vary in length from 1 hour to 6 hours. Most tests will ascertain your reading comprehension skills, quantitative and logical reasoning skills, and writing abilities. Some also focus on specific technical information in your area of study and are more like achievement tests. Examples of typical admissions tests include:

- Miller Analogies Test (M.A.T.)
- Graduate Management Admission Test (GMAT)
- Law School Admission Test (LSAT)
- Medical Related Tests (MCAT, D.A.T., O.A.T.)

Most schools publish their admitted students' average test scores, and you should research the scores to know the typical ranges. The published scores will help you gain a realistic view of where you stand as you start to take practice tests and determine if you should sign up for a preparation course. Test prep courses such as The Princeton Review and Kaplan can be costly but may be a wise investment for you, especially if you tend not to perform well on standardized tests.

Note the filing dates, especially for Sabbath observers. Make sure you meet the deadlines. For specific test administration dates or names of local test centers, call [E.T.S.](tel:609-771-7670) at 609-771-7670 or [1-866-473-4373](tel:1-866-473-4373).

RESOURCES

For certain graduate schools, including law school and medical school, Yeshiva University's advisement centers offer specialized assistance. Be sure to join the relevant email listserv if you are pre-law or pre-med, make an appointment with an advisor, and join the relevant student societies or clubs to get the most current information about applications and the entire graduate school process. There are also many useful websites, such as graduateguide.com and studentdoctor.com, where you can find more information and resources.

ESSAYS

The essay is an opportunity to show the admissions committee that you are more than just your G.P.A. or test scores. Schools want to know your ideas and goals in pursuing a graduate degree, and they want to assess your writing abilities. Spend time on your essays— schools do read them!

Some graduate schools have centralized application services (PTCAS, AMCAS, ADEA, CASPA, Nursing C.A.S., LSAC, etc.) where an applicant writes one personal statement (P.S.) that is then sent to all schools. Therefore, one should not be specific on why they are interested in a particular school but instead focus on why that particular career (M.D., M.S.W., D.D.S., PsyD/Ph.D., etc.). After schools receive this general P.S., each school will follow up with the applicant sending them supplemental essays to write specifically to that school. Not all schools or graduate programs participate in a centralized application service system. Therefore, you should write your personal statement for these schools directly for the program you are applying to, and you should make it school and program specific.

Some general rules to follow when writing the essay can include:

- Tailor the essay to each school's application (except if part of the centralized system).
- The more academic the program, the more they want to hear about your research or a discussion of an academic issue in the field.
- The more practical and applied the program, the more personal you can be.

Make sure you spend time thinking about what makes you different, so your essay can stand out. Avoid grandiose adjectives and resume-like lists.

- Discuss your accomplishments and how you have overcome challenges.
- Detail specific experiences and make it personal.
- Discuss your growth and what you've learned from your experiences about yourself, others, or the field.
- Be reflective.
- Make sure you've answered all the questions!
- Proofread for content, grammar, and spelling, limit essay to word count, character and spaces count, page limit, and carefully follow any specific rules regarding spacing, font type/font size, margins, etc.
- Have someone double-check it to make sure it reads well and there are no mistakes!
- Send your applications in early. For online applications, make sure that each document is uploaded correctly. For paper applications, make sure each application is in the correct envelope.



LETTERS OF RECOMMENDATION

Most graduate schools request three letters of recommendation.

In choosing references, you should:

- Ask people who know you well and who will write strong recommendations.
- Have at least one recommendation from a professor in your field of study. The others may be from faculty or job supervisors.
- Consider the type of program to which you are applying. The more academic the program, the more significant number of academic references (professors with Ph.D.'s) you should secure.
- Remember that someone is doing you a favor in writing a recommendation—be gracious and be sure to give them an ample amount of time to write the letter.

If you are uncertain whether or not to ask individuals to write you a letter, set up a meeting with them, discuss your intentions for graduate study, and ask them if they would feel comfortable writing a strong letter on your behalf. Having this discussion gives them the option of saying no or ensuring that if they say yes, your letter will be strong. Once a professional agrees to write you a letter of recommendation, send them a copy of your resume, transcript, and personal statement so that they can have a fuller picture of who you are.

Most applications are online. The applicant is to list their recommenders' names with their email addresses so that the schools can send online recommendation forms directly for them to fill out online.

You will need to indicate if you wish to waive the right to see the recommendation on the recommendation form. We suggest that you waive the right as it usually increases the recommendation's validity in the admissions officers' eyes.

INTERVIEWS

Not all schools require one, but they are usually required by medical schools, graduate programs in psychology and social work, and several others. You may request one if you feel it will strengthen your application. An interview can be a significant opportunity for you to persuade an institution's admissions office or committee that you would be an asset to its program. Interviewers are interested in the way you think and approach problems.

You may be asked questions on such topics as:

- Your motivation for pursuing graduate study and that program specifically.
- Your personal philosophy.
- Your career goals, related research, and areas of interest.

In addition to traditional interview questions (why you are interested in the program, school, area of study, strengths/weakness, greatest accomplishment/failure), be prepared for behavioral interview questions, situational questions, ethical questions, and questions regarding current events and your stance on them. So, make sure to read up on issues in your field of study as well as current affairs. You may schedule a mock interview with the Shevet Glaubach Center for Career Strategy and Professional Development staff to help you prepare.

As with a job interview, you need to prepare by speaking to alumni and professors and reviewing the school website. Think about your answers to some of the questions above and do further research to discover other typical questions asked during interviews for your area of study. Also, be prepared to ask questions during the interview. Know your essay and resume inside out, as many questions may arise from them. Find out what kind of interview it will be: group, one-on-one (one interviewer for one candidate), three-on-one (three interviews for one candidate), a whole day, half-day, etc. Dress as you would for a job interview in professional attire.



APPLICATION MATERIAL COMPLETION

It is your responsibility to be on top of the application process. You will generally need to send the following:

- Official transcripts: file a transcript request form with the registrar's office.
- Official transcript from EACH school you have attended, including Israel.
- You will also need official transcripts if you have taken summer courses elsewhere and had them transferred to graduate or if you enrolled in college-level courses in high school and received college credit for them.
- Official scores from the graduate admissions tests.
- Completed application, essay, and letters of recommendation for each school.

If your admissions application is incomplete, you will not be considered for entrance. Pay attention to deadlines!!!

FINAL NOTES

In the end, the admissions committee will review the completed applications looking at G.P.A., admission test scores, essays, letters of recommendation, and interviews. No one factor can guarantee admission, but rather a combination of all factors. Graduate schools are looking for a diversified class. If you do not get into graduate school on the first try but are determined to reapply, you might contact the schools and inquire why you were not accepted.

See if there is anything you can do to strengthen your application for next year when you reapply. Inquiring about ways to improve your candidacy for next year can often be viewed as favorable. Ultimately, you will be the one to decide how committed you are to pursuing graduate school

